



Macedonia



Area 9,781 sq miles
(25,333 sq km)
Population 2.1 million
Capital Skopje
Currency Macedonian denar
Official languages Albanian
and Macedonian
Life expectancy 74 years



The Republic of Macedonia is a landlocked nation in southeastern Europe. Formerly part of Yugoslavia, which collapsed in 1992, it remains one of the poorest former Yugoslav countries, with more than 30 percent unemployment. Slav Macedonians make up the majority of the population, with ethnic Albanians forming the minority.

Bulgaria



Area 42,822 sq miles
(110,910 sq km)
Population 7.4 million
Capital Sofia
Currency Lev
Official language Bulgarian
Life expectancy 73 years



Bulgaria extends south from the Danube River, with the Black Sea to its east. The country was under a Communist regime until 1989, after which it became a democracy. Bulgaria's thermal and nuclear power plants have made it a major producer and exporter of energy in southeast Europe.

Croatia



Area 21,831 sq miles
(56,542 sq km)
Population 4.4 million
Capital Zagreb
Currency Kuna
Official language Croatian
Life expectancy 76 years



From medieval times, Croatia was controlled by Hungary. It was a part of the Yugoslav state for much of the 20th century, becoming a republic in 1991. Croatia has very few minerals, although it does have oil and gas fields. The Adriatic Sea's rich fishing grounds are a major natural resource.

Turkey



Area 301,384 sq miles
(780,580 sq km)
Population 73.6 million
Capital Ankara
Currency Turkish lira
Official language Turkish
Life expectancy 71 years



Turkey's location, straddling both the European and the Asian continents, gives it great strategic influence over the Black Sea, the Mediterranean, and the Middle East. Most Turks are Sunni Muslim, though the Shi'a community is growing fast. Turkey is projected to have a larger population than any EU country by 2020.

Serbia



Area 29,905 sq miles
(77,453 sq km)
Population 9.9 million
Capital Belgrade
Currency Serbian dinar
Official language Serbian
Life expectancy 73 years



Serbia became a sovereign republic after the union of Serbia and Montenegro ended in 2006. Ethnic conflicts in the 1990s greatly affected Serbian society. The mainly Albanian province of Kosovo, which rebelled against Serbian rule, declared independence in 2008.

Bosnia and Herzegovina



Area 19,741 sq miles
(51,129 sq km)
Population 3.8 million
Capital Sarajevo
Currency Maraka
Official languages Bosnian,
Serbian, and Croatian
Life expectancy 75 years



Following the collapse of Yugoslavia, Bosnia and Herzegovina suffered devastating internal conflicts in the 1990s. These were fought between the Muslim Bosniaks, Orthodox Christian Serbs, and Roman Catholic Croats. The country received aid from the EU and the United States to rebuild its economy.



▲ **STUFFED VINE LEAVES**
Dolma, a popular Turkish dish, consists of vegetables or meat wrapped in vine leaves. The dish is also common in the Balkans, the Middle East, and in Central and South Asia.

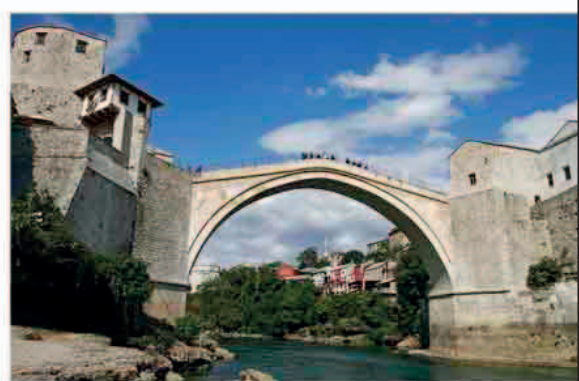
Montenegro



Area 5,333 sq miles
(13,812 sq km)
Population 600,000
Capital Podgorica
Currency Euro
Official language Montenegrin
Life expectancy 74 years



The tiny republic of Montenegro, which literally means "Black Mountain," became independent in 2006 when it split from Serbia. It was formerly part of Yugoslavia. With its many scenic beaches, Montenegro's tourist industry is rapidly expanding. However, rural poverty is widespread.



▲ **STARI MOST BRIDGE**
Located over the Neretva River is the country's most recognizable landmark. The bridge was originally built by the Ottomans in 1566.